

Convert CSV file to TSV (tab-separated values) using Python stdlib

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Converts comma-separated values (CSV) to tab-separated values (TSV) using Python's standard library csv module.

Language

python

Category

data-processing

Command

```
python3 -c "import sys, csv; csv.writer(sys.stdout, delimiter='\\t').writerows(csv.reader(sys.stdin))"
```

Explanation

The command reads CSV data from stdin, parses it with `csv.reader` (default delimiter is comma), and writes it to stdout using `csv.writer` with tab delimiter. It preserves quoting and escaping rules.

Tags

python, csv, tsv, data-conversion, text-processing

Dependencies

python3

Arguments

1. **INPUT_FILE** (Optional): CSV input file (use stdin redirection)
Default: stdin
2. **OUTPUT_FILE** (Optional): TSV output file (use stdout redirection)
Default: stdout

Examples

1. `python3 -c "import sys, csv; csv.writer(sys.stdout, delimiter='\\{t').writerows(csv.read(< data.csv > data.tsv - Convert data.csv to data.tsv`
2. `cat data.csv | python3 -c "import sys, csv; csv.writer(sys.stdout, delimiter='\\{t').writerows(csv.reader(sys.stdin))" | head -20`
- Preview first 20 rows converted

Output

col1	col2	col3
value1	value2	value3

Notes

- Handles quoted fields with commas correctly
- Preserves newlines within quoted fields
- Works with any CSV dialect compatible with Python's csv module

Warnings

- Large files may consume memory as all rows are read into list
- Input must be valid CSV format

See Also

- [tsv-to-csv](#)

Status

reviewed

Safety

safe

Shell

posix

Platforms

linux, gnu-linux, freebsd, openbsd, netbsd

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